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@ccess Over The Airwaves

Data cards offer you wireless connectivity over mobile networks, but do they offer the kind of speeds you need?

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About a decade ago, we were awed at the climactic sequence in Mission Impossible (the original, not the sequel) in which a top-secret list is transmitted from a laptop on the London-Paris TGV—France's high-speed railway. Wireless Net access has certainly become more commonplace! Mobile data access is now increasingly seen as an efficiency enhancer by large and small businesses.

Take the example of a marketing executive of a large corporate. Apart from being e-mail enabled, he also needs to access the company intranet from various locations within the country or even abroad. Wi-Fi is one of the answers to such needs.

Wi-Fi And WiMax

Wi-Fi implements the Wireless LAN specifications detailed under section 802.11 by the IEEE. It envisaged the creation of areas from where one's computing device could access the Internet. However, Wi-Fi penetration in India is largely limited to offices, airports, five-star hotels, and in some cases, university campuses. A notable exception is Bangalore with its public Wi-Fi centres.

Perhaps future implementations of WiMax will finally allow us to have *real* "anytime, any-

